

01 / BEFORE THE CALL

The first interview should resolve something.

A 30-minute guide for a lifecycle marketing hire. Adapt the work and questions to the role before meeting a candidate.

The requirement, written plainly

“Own the welcome and post-purchase flows in Klaviyo. Agree audience rules with the ecommerce lead, coordinate copy and design, run pre-send checks, and keep a short delivery log.”

Decide what you need to learn

Question to resolve	Evidence worth discussing
Can they own the flow logic?	One relevant journey, its entry condition, the send-time checks and the reason a customer leaves it.
Can they deliver with others?	What they supplied to the writer or designer, how they reviewed the build, and how they handled an unresolved dependency.
Can they explain their own work?	The candidate's contribution, what someone else owned, what changed during delivery and what they would now do differently.
Can the arrangement work?	Interest, availability, working overlap, engagement terms and expectations. Confirm these directly rather than infer them.

Avoid the impossible shopping list

Separate essential skills from skills the team can support. If the work combines strategy, writing, design, implementation and reporting, make the ownership split explicit before judging one person against all five.

02 / RUN THE CONVERSATION

Thirty minutes. One useful decision.

Tell the candidate what the conversation covers and leave time for their questions. Use follow-ups to understand reasoning, not to catch them out.

Time	The conversation
00-05	Explain the team, the work waiting to be owned and what success would look like in the first delivery cycle.
05-15	Ask for a relevant project. What was the brief? What did they personally decide? What did they build or coordinate? Where did the plan change?
15-20	Use the purchase scenario below. Ask the candidate to walk through their checks and identify anything they would need to verify.
20-25	Discuss handoffs, QA and an example of a mistake they found. Ask what evidence showed the fix worked.
25-30	Candidate questions, practical terms still unresolved, and the next step with a named owner and expected timing.

A situation to discuss

“A subscriber receives the first welcome email and buys twelve hours later. The next email is scheduled for tomorrow. What needs to happen before that message sends?”

Useful follow-ups

Where is purchase state checked? What happens if the event arrives late? How would you test the rule before launch? Which parts would you verify in the actual account rather than assume from memory?

03 / WRITE THE DEBRIEF

Write down evidence while it is still specific.

Keep observation, interpretation and open questions separate. These examples illustrate the note format; they are not records of a real candidate.

Avoid this note	Write something reviewable
"Strong technical fit."	"Explained entry conditions and send-time purchase checks. Described how to test a purchase between emails. We have not yet seen a build or QA record."
"Good communicator."	"Separated their own implementation from the designer's work and explained a delayed handoff, the decision made and what happened next."
"Probably available soon."	"Availability and working overlap are still unconfirmed. Ask directly before arranging the next interview."

Before sharing the shortlist

Include the role, relevant evidence, unresolved questions, confirmed practical terms and the next interviewer. Let the hiring team make a decision from the work requirements and evidence; avoid a score that hides what is still unknown.

Build the brief

[Open the Role Brief Builder](#). It includes lifecycle, backend and email-design examples and produces a plain-text brief you can edit with the hiring manager.